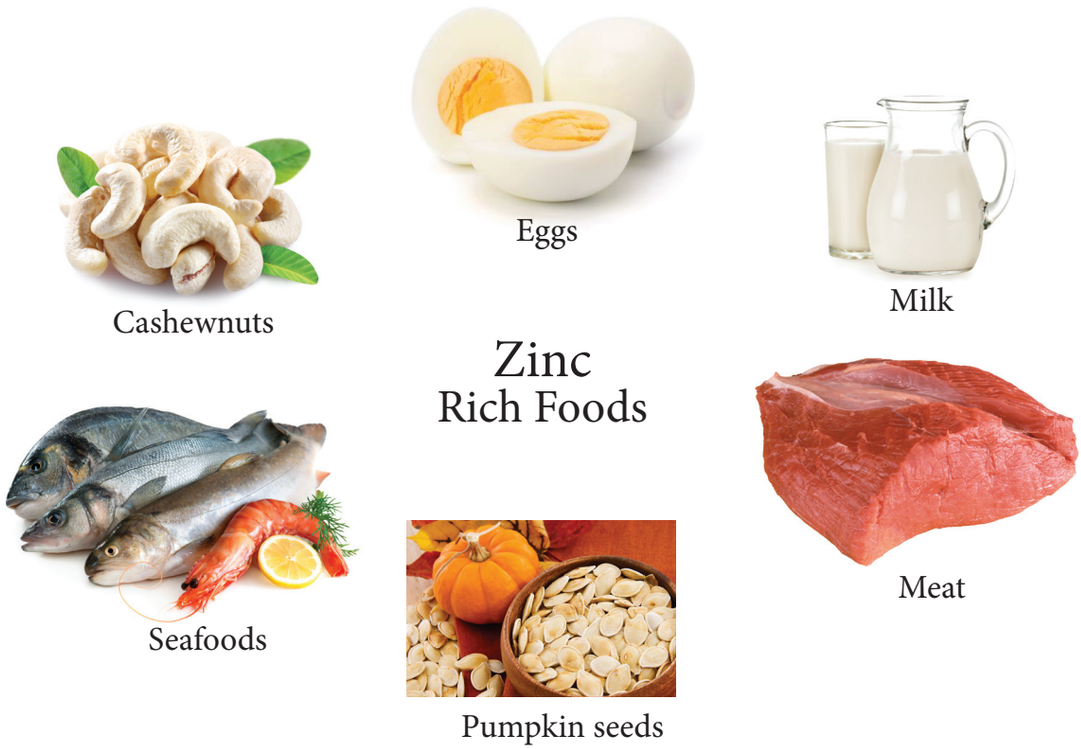


Fig 11.25: Food Sources of Zinc

11.4.5 Sodium

Sodium is a plentiful mineral in the body. It is essential in the recommended quantity for the body. A 50kg person would contain around 200g of sodium chloride Sodium is easily absorbed in the small intestine. Sodium is lost in sweat during exercise or in hot environments. Sodium and chloride compound is table salt.

Functions:

- Sodium is the most abundant cation in the extracellular fluid of the body.
- It acts with other electrolytes, especially potassium, in the intracellular fluid to regulate the osmotic pressure and maintain proper water balance within the body.
- It is the major factor in maintaining the acid-base equilibrium, in transmitting nerve impulses and in relaxing muscles.
- It maintains normal mineral content of extra and intra cellular fluid.

Food Sources of Sodium:

Vegetables like dry lotus stems and green leafy vegetables, dried fruits, roots like beetroot, carrot and radish are rich in sodium. Animal foods like milk, egg white, fish and meat contain substantial amount of sodium.

Symptoms of Sodium deficiency:

- Deficiency of sodium is caused by excessive sweating, prolonged use of diuretics, chronic diarrhoea.
- Deficiency may lead to nausea, muscular weakness, heat exhaustion and mental apathy. Oversupply of sodium is a more common problem because of overuse of dietary sodium chloride or common salt.

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